



Chapter 7

User personas

22 → first child · building a life

The story turns from "me" to "us": choosing a partner, merging two families and two bank accounts, dividing the invisible work, and fielding the loudest question in India, "when's the wedding, when's the baby?". India-segmented personas for the years when a life gets built, fairly or not.

From "me" to "us", without disappearing.

Chapter 6 was about standing on your own. Chapter 7 is about building a life with someone else, and with their family, their money and their expectations attached. The pressures are no longer institutional; they are relational and social: the marriage timeline, the in-laws, the mental load nobody names, the question of children that everyone but you seems to have answered. The brand's wry-but-kind register holds, and the job shifts from "find yourself" to "build something fair, and don't lose yourself doing it".

Four shifts from Chapter 6

SHIFT	WHAT IT MEANS	WHAT THE DESIGN MUST DO
It's a two-person game now	Choosing, merging and negotiating a shared life, not just self-management.	Content for partnership and fairness, not just the individual.
The invisible work appears	The mental load and the second shift land, unequally and unnamed.	Make the unseen labour seen; reach the unaware partner.
Family scales up	In-laws, joint households and "log kya kahenge" shape daily life.	Couple-unit boundaries; navigate elders without rupture.
The loaded questions	Marry / don't, kids / don't, and the stigma attached to either.	Defend "your path, your call"; honest if/when/whether.

Eight personas: six users across Indian segments, two reach channels. Each ends in design implications for the nine Chapter 7 games: Choosing & Building, Your Path Your Call, Equal Partners, Respect at Home, The Family Map, Money Together, If When & Whether, and Many Ways to Family.

Two people, two families, one fragile fairness.

The users are the couples and the would-be-coupled; the channels are the people they reach when building a life gets hard, a counsellor and a women's-rights worker.

PERSONA	ROLE	SEGMENT	IN ONE LINE	THE LEVER FOR DEPTH
Pooja, 27	User	Urban, joint family	Works full-time, runs the home alone.	Name the mental load.
Karthik, 29	User	Urban	A "modern husband" who "helps".	Reach the unaware partner.
Sneha, 31	User	Metro, single	Happy, and constantly asked why she's single.	Single and childfree as full lives.
Aditya, 30	User	Urban, queer	Wants a family the law won't let him build.	Many ways to family; real barriers.
Nisha, 33	User	Urban	"When's the good news?" on a loop.	If / when / whether, honestly.
Reshma, 24	User	Low-income	Married young, no money of her own.	Safety, money, the DV Act.
Dr. Saxena, 52	Channel	Family counsellor	Sees the cracks couples hide.	Prevention; couples; referral.
Razia, 38	Channel	Women's-rights NGO	Legal aid for women with nowhere to go.	Rights, the law, real help.

Pooja, 27

Software tester · married one year, joint family · the second shift

"We both work nine to six. Then I cook, plan, remember everything and manage his parents. He 'helps'. Everyone thinks I'm lucky."

LIVES	With husband and his parents; both work full-time.
MONEY	Earns well; finances and decisions still flow through the men.
DEVICES	Own phone; private; scrolls reels at midnight, the only quiet hour.
SUPPORT	Friends scattered; her own family far; few allies in the house.
LOAD	Carries the mental load: the lists, the remembering, the managing.

A normal Tuesday. Pooja does a full day's job, then a second unpaid one: meals, the maid, the medicines for her in-laws, the social calendar, the emotional weather of the house. Her husband is kind and "helps when asked", which means she still has to manage him too. She is not unhappy with him; she is exhausted by a deal she never agreed to, and slightly ashamed of resenting a life she's told is enviable.

What she wants

- To share the load, not be thanked for carrying it.
- Words for the invisible work, so it stops being invisible.
- A way to raise it with her husband that lands, not fights.
- To stop feeling guilty for wanting fairness.

Why she'd bounce

- Content that tells her to "communicate better" as if it's her job to fix.
- Anything that frames her exhaustion as ingratitude.
- A lecture she can't actually use in her real house.

BORING TO POOJA

A "self-care tips for busy women" listicle. It adds one more task to her list.

The myth she carries

That the home is hers to run, that a husband who helps is a prize, and that wanting equal partnership is asking too much.

Adjusting is the wife's job.

He helps, so he's a great husband.

She needs the load named and a tool that moves her husband, not just her.

MAGIC TO POOJA

Something that names the mental load out loud, and gives her a way to redraw the deal that her husband actually hears.

Design implications

- 1 Make the mental load visible and nameable, the invisible third shift of remembering and managing.
- 2 Give her language and tools to renegotiate, not just "communicate better".
- 3 Validate the resentment; fairness is not ingratitude.
- 4 Design content that moves the partner too, not only the woman.

Karthik, 29

Product manager · married · the "good guy" who can't see it

"I'm not like my dad. I help with everything. I genuinely don't get why she's so stressed all the time."

LIVES	With his wife and parents; sees himself as progressive.
MONEY	Out-earns slightly; quietly assumes that buys him out of home work.
DEVICES	Heavy user; would never read a "how to be a better husband" article.
SUPPORT	Male friends who model the same "I help" standard.
BLIND SPOT	Genuinely cannot see the planning, only the tasks he's asked to do.

He really means well. Karthik is the manosphere kid two stages on (Veer, then Rohan, now this), reformed enough to reject the worst of it, but still carrying the quiet assumption that the home is fundamentally hers and he is a helpful guest in it. He is not a villain; he is unaware. Shame him and he gets defensive. Show him the load he can't see, framed as competence and partnership, and he can change.

What he wants

- A happy marriage and to be a good husband (he believes he is one).
- To understand why his wife is stressed when he "does so much".
- To not feel attacked for trying.
- Practical, concrete things to do, not abstract guilt.

The myth he carries

That earning is his half, that helping equals sharing, and that being better than his father is the same as being fair.

~~Earn, so home is her department.~~

~~Helping out makes me a modern man.~~

The shift is from "helping" to "owning"; he needs to see the load, not be blamed for it.

Why he'd bounce

- Being called part of the patriarchy; instant shutdown.
- Earnest "do better" messaging with no respect for his effort.
- Anything that feels like his wife's complaint in app form.

BACKFIRES FOR KARTHIK

A guilt-trip about privilege. He files it under "she's been complaining to an app now".

MAGIC TO KARTHIK

A sharp, respectful reveal of the invisible work he never noticed, and concrete ways to actually own his half.

Design implications

- 1 Reach the partner directly; do not make this a women-only topic.
- 2 Reframe "helping" as "owning"; show the planning, not just the chores.
- 3 Lead with respect for his intent; never shame; concrete over abstract.
- 4 Continue the male arc: a fair partner is the confident, grown-up man.

Sneha, 31

Marketing director · metro · single, and tired of explaining it

"I have a career I love, friends, a flat. At every wedding someone whispers that it's a shame, na, such a nice girl, still alone."

LIVES	On her own in a metro; financially independent.
STATUS	Single by a mix of choice and circumstance; open to a partner, not desperate.
DEVICES	Fully online adult; dating apps on and off; done with bad setups.
SUPPORT	Strong friendships; family loving but anxious and relentless.
PRESSURE	The "settle down" and "biological clock" chorus from everyone.

The whisper. Sneha's life is, by any honest measure, good. Yet society has one script for a woman past thirty, and she is failing it on purpose. Relatives pity her, aunties pray for her, apps exhaust her, and a quiet voice asks whether she's left it too late, for marriage, for kids, for a story that was never really hers. She doesn't need rescuing into a wedding; she needs the world's verdict on single women to stop being the only verdict she hears.

What she wants

- Her single life affirmed as a full life, not a waiting room.
- Honest, unpressured facts on fertility and her real options.
- If she does want a partner, a saner way to choose one.
- Language to deflect the relentless "when will you settle".

Why she'd bounce

- Anything that treats marriage as the goal and her as incomplete.
- Panic-merchant "your clock is ticking" content.
- Cutesy "find love" gamification; she's a grown woman.

INSULTING TO SNEHA

A "how to finally find the one" course. It accepts the very premise she rejects.

The myth she carries

The one the whole room hands her: that an unmarried woman is unfinished, and that her worth has an expiry date.

An unmarried woman is incomplete.

Your clock is ticking, hurry.

She needs the choice itself made legitimate, and the facts to own it.

MAGIC TO SNEHA

Content that treats single and childfree as full, valid lives, gives her honest fertility facts, and hands her a comeback for the aunties.

Design implications

- 1 Treat single, childfree and divorced as complete lives, never as failure states.
- 2 Give honest, calm fertility and options information, free of panic.
- 3 If she wants a partner, support sane choosing (values over timeline).
- 4 Hand her language to deflect stigma without a family war.

Aditya, 30

Designer · urban · partnered, wants a family the law won't let him build

"We've been together five years. We can open a joint bank account now. We can't marry, and I can't adopt a daughter. So what counts as our family?"

LIVES	With his long-term partner; out to friends, partly to family.
STATUS	Committed couple; legally, two strangers who live together.
DEVICES	Fully online; finds community and information for himself.
SUPPORT	Chosen family strong; biological family cautious; few legal options.
BARRIERS	No marriage, no joint adoption; as a single man, barred from adopting a girl.

Building anyway. Aditya and his partner want what many want: a home, commitment, maybe a child. India offers them no marriage (the Supreme Court declined in 2023 and rejected the review in 2025), so no joint adoption; and under CARRA a single man cannot adopt a girl child at all. They are building a real family with almost no legal scaffolding. He needs honest information about what is actually possible, and a product that simply counts his family as a family.

What he wants

- His relationship and family recognised as real, legal status or not.
- Clear, accurate information on the routes that do exist.
- Help navigating family acceptance on his own terms.
- To plan a future without pretending the barriers aren't there.

The myth he's up against

That a family requires a marriage, a mother and a father, and that people like him simply cannot have one.

~~A real family is a man, a woman, kids.~~
~~People like us can't have a family.~~

He needs many-ways-to-family treated as fact, with the real barriers named, not wished away.

Why he'd bounce

- Content that assumes "family" means a married man and woman.
- Naive optimism that ignores the real legal walls.
- Tokenism that mentions queer people once and moves on.

ERASING TO ADITYA
A "starting a family" module that is one straight married couple from start to finish.

MAGIC TO ADITYA
Honest, inclusive guidance on the many ways to build a family, the real legal limits, and the routes that genuinely exist.

Design implications

- 1 Make many-ways-to-family the default: single, queer, adoptive, child-free, all real.
- 2 Be accurate about Indian law: no same-sex marriage; CARRA's single-man, no-girl-child rule.
- 3 Inform without false hope; name the barriers and the genuine routes.
- 4 Count his relationship as a relationship throughout, never a special case.

ADULT · THE PLAYER

Nisha, 33

Architect · urban · married, and the whole family is "waiting"

"Three years married, so now it's 'any good news?' at every call. Nobody asks if we want a child, or whether we're even able to have one."

LIVES	With her husband; both careers in full flight.
STATUS	Genuinely unsure about kids; also quietly facing fertility questions.
DEVICES	Researches privately at 2am: IVF, costs, "is it too late", childfree.
SUPPORT	Husband on the same page; extended family relentlessly not.
PRESSURE	"Good news", son-preference hints, and a fertility clock weaponised by others.

The waiting room nobody booked. Nisha is at the crossroads of one of life's biggest, most personal choices, and the whole extended family has appointed itself to decide it for her. She doesn't have clear, calm facts about fertility, IVF or what's actually true about age and risk; she has aunties, anxiety and 2am searches. Whether she ends up with a child, by birth or adoption, or chooses a child-free life, she deserves to make it as a decision, not a surrender.

What she wants

- To decide about children herself, with her partner, on the facts.
- Honest information on fertility, age, IVF and adoption.
- Permission for "not yet", "never", or "another way" to be valid.
- A shield against the "good news" and son-preference pressure.

The myth she carries

That a married woman owes a child (ideally a son) on a schedule, and that not wanting one is unnatural.

~~When's the good news? It must be a boy.~~

~~A woman who doesn't want kids is selfish.~~

She needs the choice returned to her, with real facts and no shame.

Why she'd bounce

- Content that assumes everyone wants, and can have, a baby.
- Shaming of the child-free, or of infertility.
- Scare tactics dressed up as fertility "awareness".

PAINFUL TO NISHA

A glowing "your pregnancy journey" flow. It assumes the very thing she's still deciding.

MAGIC TO NISHA

Calm, honest facts on fertility and every path, including child-free, and clear backing that the choice is hers.

Design implications

- 1 Frame children as if / when / whether, never as the assumed default.
- 2 Give honest fertility, IVF and adoption facts, free of panic and shame.
- 3 Counter son-preference and "good news" pressure head-on.
- 4 Make child-free and many-paths-to-parenthood equally valid.

Reshma, 24

Homemaker · low-income · married at 19, no money of her own

"He gives me money for vegetables and asks for the change. If I want to visit my mother, I have to ask. I tell myself this is normal."

LIVES	With husband and in-laws; married young; one small child.
MONEY	No income or account of her own; every rupee is controlled.
DEVICES	Uses the family phone with permission; little privacy.
SUPPORT	Isolated from her own family; an ASHA worker visits sometimes.
RISK	Financial and emotional control; the early signs of abuse, normalised.

"This is just marriage." Reshma's situation looks ordinary from outside and is quietly coercive within: controlled money, restricted movement, permission for everything, the constant message that her worth is her service. She would not call it abuse, and India's law would not call forced sex within her marriage rape (the exception survives in the new criminal code). But the Domestic Violence Act does name economic and emotional abuse, and there is help, if she ever learns it exists.

What she wants

- To feel that her life and choices are partly her own.
- To understand that control over money and movement is not normal.
- Some financial footing, however small, of her own.
- To know that help and rights exist, quietly and safely.

Why she'd bounce

- Anything that could be seen on the shared phone and endanger her.
- English, text-heavy, or accusatory "leave him" messaging.
- Content that shames her for staying or for not knowing.

The myth she carries

That privacy of the home excuses control, and that a husband who earns owns the money, the movements and the say.

What happens at home is private.

He controls the money because he earns it.

She needs to name it safely, and to know the Domestic Violence Act and helplines exist.

UNSAFE FOR RESHMA

A loud "know your rights, leave him" app she could never open without risk.

MAGIC TO RESHMA

A private, spoken, gentle guide that names control as not-okay, builds small financial footing, and quietly points to real help.

Design implications

- 1 Name coercive control and economic abuse plainly; "private" is not a shield.
- 2 Be accurate and useful: the Domestic Violence Act 2005 covers economic and emotional abuse; signpost helplines.
- 3 Safety-first design: discreet, offline, in-language, a quick exit; never endanger her.
- 4 Build small financial agency; never shame her for staying or not knowing.

Dr. Saxena, 52

Couples and family counsellor · sees the cracks behind the wedding photos

"They arrive years too late, when resentment has set like concrete. I wish they'd learned the basics before the first big fight."

Reality

- Sees mental-load resentment, in-law conflict, intimacy and money fights, DV.
- Most couples arrive in crisis, with no shared language for fairness.
- Does pre-marital and couples work; demand far exceeds her time.
- Knows prevention would spare most of the pain she treats.

WRONG FOR HER

Generic "10 tips for a happy marriage". It can't touch real power, money or safety dynamics.

What she needs from SwipeEd. Something she can give couples before and between sessions: shared, plain content on the mental load, money, boundaries and consent that builds a common vocabulary, so they can name a problem instead of just fighting it. A first line that does the basics at scale, and a clear path to refer the cases, especially abuse, that need a human and the law.

MAGIC TO DR. SAXENA

Shared, honest content couples can do together that names the real issues, plus safe referral for abuse and crisis.

Design implications

- 1 Build couple-facing, shared content that creates a common vocabulary, used together.
- 2 Tackle the real dynamics: load, money, boundaries, consent, not platitudes.
- 3 Work as prevention, before and between counselling.
- 4 Refer abuse and crisis clearly to human help and the law.

WOMEN'S-RIGHTS WORKER

Razia, 38

Women's-rights NGO and legal-aid worker · the help that reaches the Reshmas

"By the time a woman calls me, she's been told for years that it's normal. My first job is helping her believe it isn't."

Reality

- Supports women facing domestic violence, economic abuse and abandonment.
- Works the Domestic Violence Act, maintenance, helplines and shelters.
- Reaches low-income, isolated, often non-literate women.
- Battles the belief, in clients and society, that control is just marriage.

DANGEROUS FOR HER CLIENTS

A flashy rights app with no privacy. It can get a woman caught and hurt.

What she needs from SwipeEd. Offline, in-language, safety-first content she can share with women who have no privacy and no money, that names abuse without endangering them, explains rights in plain terms, and connects to real help. A tool that does early awareness, so women reach her sooner, and that respects how dangerous the wrong screen at the wrong moment can be.

MAGIC TO RAZIA

A discreet, offline, spoken guide that names abuse safely, explains the law simply, and routes quietly to real help.

Design implications

- 1 Safety-first for at-risk women: discreet, offline, in-language, quick-exit.
- 2 Explain the Domestic Violence Act and rights in plain, usable terms.
- 3 Do early awareness so women reach help sooner.
- 4 Route to helplines, legal aid and shelters; never just inform and leave.

What Chapter 7 must do differently.

Across all eight personas, one demand dominates: help two people (and two families) build something fair, name the things polite content avoids, and defend each person's right to their own path.

PRINCIPLE	BECAUSE	SHOWS UP AS
Build "us" without erasing "me"	Partnership shouldn't mean one person dissolving into a family.	Two-equals content; fairness, not self-sacrifice.
Name the invisible work	The mental load is unequal, unseen and unspoken.	Make the load visible; reach the unaware partner, not just the woman.
Your path, your call	Single, childfree and divorced carry heavy, unfair stigma.	Every path treated as a full life; comebacks for the chorus.
Safety and consent at home	"Private" hides coercion; the law leaves real gaps.	Name marital consent and economic abuse; the DV Act; safe routes.
Money is power	Control of money is control of a person.	Joint finances, transparency, the homemaker's value, independence.
Honest about family	If/when/whether, and many ways to family, are loaded and real.	Fertility facts, child-free as valid, adoption and queer family, with real law.
Reach the vulnerable safely	The most at-risk have the least privacy and money.	Offline, in-language, discreet; route to legal aid and helplines.
Just-in-time at the decision	People engage at the proposal, the fight, the merge, the question.	Searchable, on-demand, couple-facing where it helps.

The same principles, on the nine Chapter 7 games

GAME	THE DEPTH MOVE FROM THESE PERSONAS
Choosing & Building (g53)	Compatibility and shared values over spark and timeline; for Sneha and Aditya alike.
Your Path, Your Call (g54)	Single, childfree and divorced as full lives; dismantle the unmarried-woman stigma.
Equal Partners (g55)	Name the mental load; move Karthik from "helping" to owning his half.
Respect at Home (g56)	Marital consent and coercive control; the DV Act where criminal law still won't go.
The Family Map (g57)	Couple-unit boundaries with in-laws and elders; navigate without rupture.
Money, Together (g58)	Transparency over control; the homemaker's value; Reshma's financial footing.
If, When & Whether (g59)	Honest fertility facts; child-free valid; counter son-preference and "good news".
Many Ways to Family (g60)	

Adoption (CARA's single-man, no-girl-child rule), ART, single and queer families, named truthfully.

Next: Chapter 8 (parenthood and the Parent Layer), which closes the generational loop back to Chapter 1, or a Chapter 7 game-by-game redesign built on this brief.